When the River Moved: Ten Years on the Sallow Plain

By Ines Varga, staff writer

Why the river moved

In the spring of 2016, the Sallow River left the bed it had followed for more than a century. Heavy rain in the hills sent a flood down the valley in just two days. The water broke through a low bank near the village of Orrin and cut a new channel to the east.

Geologists later found that the old bank had been weakened by decades of gravel mining. Nobody had measured the bank since 1987, so the risk was invisible. Within a week, the new channel was carrying almost all of the river's water.

What the farmers did

The farmers on the plain lost about a third of their fields to the new channel. Instead of rebuilding the old bank, they agreed to farm on both sides of the new river. A small ferry now carries tractors across the water twice a day.

Ten years later, the soil near the new channel is among the richest in the region. Yields of barley have risen by almost a fifth since the flood. The village council plans to measure the banks every spring from now on.